

THE GARAMUT



A MESSAGE SENDER

Ps Barry's Reflections on: **PRAYER, PROCLAMATION and PERSONAL PROGRESS**

Bethel Global Missions
No.5. 26th February 2024



TENDERNESS

Recently during a time of reflection, the word “*tenderness*” came to me, and I immediately felt that I should explore its meaning and specifically its relevance to the Christian believer today. Here are some of my thoughts surrounding the words tender or tenderness as found in the Bible. I am captivated with what I discovered because it has to do with my personal relationship that exists between myself and Christ.

Biblical Dictionary

The meaning of TENDER in O.T. meaning - by implication, WEAK: - FAINT (faint-hearted]: - SOFT: - TENDER (tender-hearted]: SOFTNESS (figuratively):

And in the N.T. to EXERCISE PITY: - have COMPASSION ON: - SOFT.

REFERENCES

■ JESUS - THE TENDER PLANT

- * The word tender is used in reference to Jesus Christ and his suffering found in the prophecy of Isaiah chapter 53:2-3
Isaiah 53:2 In God's eyes he was like a TENDER GREEN SHOOT, sprouting from a root in dry and sterile ground. But in our eyes there was no attractiveness at all, nothing to make us want him. TLB
- (*A TENDER PLANT in the KJV* -)

■ THE TENDER GRAPE

- * THE TENDER GRAPES ARE ALSO REFERRED TO IN THE Book of the Song of Solomon – *Songs 2:15, and 2:13, and 7:12.*
Song of Solomon 2:13 The fig tree putteth forth her green figs, and the vines WITH the TENDER GRAPE give a good smell. Arise, my love, my fair one, and come away. KJV
- * I wondered why it specifically refers to the vines having TENDER grapes. **Was this significant** and I discovered **it was**.
- * Obviously, the use of the word TENDER referred to the grapes in the early stages of their formation and of their weakness, vulnerability and the need for some care and protection.
Song of Solomon 2:15 TAKE US the foxes, the little foxes, that spoil the vines: for our vines have tender grapes. KJV

■ THE MAIDENS LOVE

*“FOR **OUR** VINES HAVE TENDER GRAPES”.*

- HERE THE MAIDEN'S EXPRESSION IS A REFERENCE TO THE LOVE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN HER AND HER LOVER-KING AND IS LIKENED TO THE TENDER GRAPES ON THE VINE, GIVING A BEAUTIFUL SMELL (PLEASANT AND ATTRACTIVE) BUT VULNERABLE AND NEEDING TO BE GUARDED AND PROTECTED

APPLICATION

- THIS ALSO APPLIES TO THE LOVE RELATIONSHIP (UNION) THAT WE HAVE WITH CHRIST AND SHOULD BE CONSIDERED AS VULNERABLE - **IF UNATTENDED OR UNGUARDED**

THE CONTEXT - verse 15

Song of Solomon 2:15 **TAKE US** the foxes, the little foxes, that spoil the vines: for our vines have tender grapes. KJV

THE MAIDENS LOVE

- THE LITTLE FOXES THAT SPOIL THE VINES AND HERE THE MAIDEN IS SPEAKING FIGURATIVELY ABOUT THE LOVE RELATIONSHIP SHE SHARES WITH HER BELOVED / LOVER - A HEALTHY VINE.
- * AND THE LITTLE FOXES AS A SYMBOL OR PICTURE OF THE DAMAGE THEY CAN CAUSE TO THE PRODUCTIVITY / FRUIT OF THE VINE, **THUS SPOILING ITS VALUE AND BEAUTY**.

■ LIKE A FRUITFUL VINEYARD

- * THE REFERENCE HERE IS TO THEIR LOVE RELATIONSHIP BEING LIKE A FRUITFUL VINEYARD AND THE LITTLE FOXES WILL **DAMAGE THE VINEYARD** UNLESS THEY ARE **STOPPED AND CAUGHT**.

CATCH THE FOXES

Song of Solomon 2:15 **CATCH** all the foxes, those little foxes, before they ruin the vineyard of love, for the grapevines are blossoming! NLT

Song of Solomon 2:15 **TAKE** us the foxes, the little foxes, that spoil the vines: for our vines have tender grapes. KJV

- * THEY ARE LITTLE (SMALL) BUT THEY CAN SPOIL THE VINE BY DAMAGING OR MARRING THE TENDER GRAPES' BEAUTY (appearance) AND VALUE AND THUS DEVALUATING THE VINE'S ABILITY TO PRODUCE BEAUTIFUL AND QUALITY FRUIT.
- * **NOTE:** The wording, "**catch** US the foxes", is a task or duty for TEAMWORK and needs all one partners involved.

THE MARRING OUR LOVE

- The Vine here in this context is a picture of our love relationship that we with Christ our beloved and the tender grapes a picture of the beautiful fruit / produce of that relationship.
- * The tender grape is in its early stages of formation and is weak, vulnerable and needs to be guarded and protected from outside predators – like the little foxes.

THE LITTLE FOXES SPOIL OR MAR THE TENDER GRAPE

- WE ARE COMMANDED TO:
- ALWAYS BE DILIGENTLY WATCHFUL AND SEEKING TO CATCH AND STOP **THE LITTLE FOXES** IN THEIR CONSTANT ENDEAVOURS TO SPOIL / DAMAGE / AFFECT THE VINE – I.E. OUR LOVE FOR CHRIST
- * OUR LOVE FOR CHRIST IS PRIMARY- (first).
- * IT IS THE MOST IMPORTANT FACTOR IN THE CHRISTIANS LIFE AND FROM THAT LOVE ALL MEANINGFUL ACTIONS AND RESPONSES TO AND FOR GOD EMANATE FROM IT.

- Hudson Taylor the missionary to China aptly describes it for us.
The "little foxes" that may ruin our relationship with Jesus Christ. "The enemies may be small, but the mischief done great. And how numerous the little foxes are!
- * Little compromises with the world;
- * Disobedience to the still small voice in little things;
- * Little indulgences of the flesh to the neglect of duty;
- * Little strokes of policy;
- * Doing evil in little things that good may come; and the beauty, and the fruitfulness of the vine are sacrificed!"

- ARE THERE ANY TENDER GRAPES NOW IN OUR LIVES?
- ARE OUR LIVES STILL CONTINUING TO PRODUCE NEW FRUIT?
- DOES OUR LOVE FOR CHRIST CONTINUE TO CAPTIVATE US, WITH FRESH AND EXCITING INSIGHTS TO US?
- IS THERE AN EVER-INCREASING PASSION FOR CHRIST AND APPRECIATION OF THE VALUE AND WORTH OF SUCH A RELATIONSHIP AS WE ENJOY?
- OR IS IT DIMINISHING OR BECOMING ORDINARY AND SEEMS TO HAVE LOST ITS LUSTRE AND ATTRACTIVENESS?

- THE MAIDEN AND HER BELOVED CONTINUE TO LOOK FOR THE VINES THAT ARE STILL PRODUCING TENDER GRAPES.

Song of Solomon 7:12 Let us get up early to the vineyards; let us see if the vine flourish, whether the tender grape appear, and the pomegranates bud forth: there will I give thee my loves. KJV

- THE FRUITFULNESS & BEAUTY OF THE VINE WAS PRIMARY.
- **THEREFORE**, WE ALSO SHOULD BE CONCERNED THAT OUR LIVES / VINES HAVE TENDER GRAPES ON THEM. AMEN - Ps BARRY